

Intro to Opinion – The Daily Gamecock

Contact Information

Assistant Opinion Editor: J.C. Vaught
Phone: (843) 412-5120
Office Hours: Sat & Sun 8AM-12PM

Opinion Editor: Anna McEachern
Phone: (339) 215-6474
Office Hours: Mon-Thurs 4PM-9PM

Required Meetings

- Full staff at 2 pm on Sunday
- Opinion Section Meeting at 2:30PM on Sunday – SJMC 320

Guide to Writing Opinion Pieces

1. Pre-writing:

- Know your subject (or Be Willing to Learn It)
 - Start with topics you have personal experience with. For example, every student can write about the student experience. Don't be afraid to tackle new or technical subjects, but you must do the research first to become an 'expert'.
 - Example: Writing about the Student Experience is something everyone can write about, but writing about EV vs ICE vehicles needs more research – especially due to technical nature.
- Find your angle (i.e. Strom being busy hurts student health)
- Find sources to back this angle up. Ideally you already know enough about the subject that you just need to search for the links; you already know where to look.
- Turn your sources and ideas into an outline – lede (angle), background, main points, quotes, conclusion

2. Statements:

- Every definitive statement must be backed up.
 - Example 1: “*USC is increasing housing prices on students*” must have a source
 - Example 2: “*It seems USC is increasing the cost to live on campus*” may not need a source
 - Example 3: “*I think USC is increasing housing prices*” does not need a source, but is generally discouraged

3. Sources

- Sources for statements must be reputable OR must be from an interview
- Sources shouldn't be other opinions – unless using as a source for opinions
 - Example: “*Some people are in outcry over a fee*”, source [Opinion: Fee increase bad for students]
- Generally, ‘Big Name’ media are more reliable for sourcing than a blog or personal website. If given the option of both, go with the bigger name.
- If interviewing, conduct in-person or over zoom/phone. Email interviews are not allowed; however, email statements are – generally from the University or government bodies.
 - The Interviewee's name (spelling too), title/year and position/major must be included.
 - Interview recordings must be sent to copy desk for review (copydesktgd@gmail.com)

4. Writing

- Aim for 800 words; minimum is 500. Print pieces need to be about 1000-1300 words.
- Writing for articles is generally split in major sections and then broken down into **grafs**. Grafs are usually 1-4 sentences (can vary) and contain a full idea.

a. The Introduction

- The **Lede**, or first graf, must be a strong, arguable statement. In the lede, you need to state your opinion, introduce the topic, and – most importantly – convey to the reader why this issue is significant. Your audience should know exactly where you stand before they even finish the first paragraph.
- The **Nutgraf**, or the second graf, grounds the reader by providing the necessary context for the story. This is the place to efficiently summarize key details like who is involved, and when and where the events are taking place.

b. The Body

A good body for an opinion piece will include elements from the categories below, although they may not follow the order exactly.

- The **Diagnosis**, or the problem, is where you lay out the problem in detail.
 - **Data and Statistics:** Use numbers to show the scale of the problem.
 - **Quotes:** Include quotes from experts, officials, or people directly affected.
 - **Anecdotes:** Tell a short, illustrative story that puts a human face on the issue.
 - **Reporting:** Reference official documents, meeting minutes, or previous news articles.
- The **Prescription** is where you Address the ‘solution’. There are 3 general types.
 - The **Solution** is a direct proposal for what should be done. You explain your plan and why it would work.
 - The **Alternative** is used when critiquing a past decision. You present the better path that *should have been taken* to highlight the flaws in the choice that was made.
 - The **Rationale** is used to explain the *reasoning* behind the problem you're diagnosing. For example, you might diagnose a bad policy and then use this section to explain the flawed financial or political logic that led to its creation.
- The **Counter-arguments** is where you engage with the opposition.
 - **Concession:** You briefly and fairly acknowledge the valid points of the other side. What would someone who disagrees with you say?
 - **Refutation:** After conceding a point, you must explain why your argument is still stronger. This is the “Yes, but...” part of your argument.

c. The Closing

There are about 3 types of closings to an opinion piece in my experience. You may mix and choose.

- **Conclusion:** A straightforward conclusion briefly restates your main point (your lede, but in new words) and summarizes your most important evidence.
- **Call-to-Action:** This type of ending tells the reader what you want them to *do*. Should they vote, sign a petition, contact a representative, or simply change their way of thinking?
- **Coda:** A coda is a final, reflective thought that comes after the main argument is finished. It's often a short anecdote or a broader, more philosophical statement that leaves the reader with something memorable to ponder. It's the emotional or thematic “tail” of your piece.

Our Software and Process

1. Using CEO – The editing platform

Go to this link to get directions on how to use CEO to write articles.

https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/1Ny3MrrlYHoWhoA8v_94U6aCxGdC1FLaz

2. Communications – Using Slack

- Turn on slack notifications
- Put your photo, name, & phone number in your slack bio

Join these channels:

- #full staff
- #opinion
- #random
- #general